



PATAUDI ON THE QUARTET

“They were the greatest Indian middle order ever when they were the top of their game two-three years ago—only Viswanath and Vijay Manjrekar come into the frame.”



LONG STAND: Laxman (left) with his first captain Tendulkar

JOHN BUCHANAN ON INDIA

“Between 2000-2004, they were the best batting side we ran up against, not just in depth but in their skills—they could play pace and spin, they could attack and defend.”

whom the others could fly free and improvise knowing that the backbeat would always hold.

The equal music of their batting together is actually conducted through long silences. Their partnerships punctuated by the occasional tap of the gloves, a few muttered words: “Have faith, have faith,” says Laxman and Dravid’s trademark “Keep going, you’re okay, you’re good, mate.” The only stream of chatter comes from Tendulkar and sometimes reserved, specially for Ganguly, in Bengali: “All the time, it’s the wrong Bengali—11 years and he still speaks it wrong.”

There are parts to their old partners they still cannot understand: Sachin’s obsession with cars, Sourav’s obsession with his bats (he is alleged to have carried 15 on one tour), Laxman’s propensity to rush in for showers even

at tea and pad up at the very last possible minute. And the perennial mind-bender: why is Rahul so serious?

They are secure enough to banter about each other but ask them if they think they form the India’s greatest ever batting generation and they palpably baulk. Tendulkar and Laxman opt for the safety of “one of the best”. Dravid says comparing eras is “silly, and I don’t want to do that.” Ganguly, never one for shy understatement says, “I would put it this way, in that period, we have contributed immensely to Indian cricket.”

Former India captain Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi places these young men in the historical context of the middle-order batsmen he has seen from the 1950s onwards. “Only G.R. Viswanath and Vijay Manjrekar would enter the picture with them in terms of ability